Open Data and Citizen Empowerment: Opening National Food Survey data

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DEFRA's open data plans

- UK Department for the Environment, Food and Rural Affairs (DEFRA) to open 8,000 datasets as part of the 'Year of British Food' - see DEFRA's Digital Blog).

- Includes opening the National Food Survey (NFS, a.k.a. 'Family Food')

- Three-tier publishing process, aim to complete in 2016:
  - Tier 1: open household data 1974-2000
  - Tier 2: raw survey data 2001 onwards
  - Tier 3: NFS reports (1940–1970s) digitised, data extracted (many already on Hathi Trust website: UK Data Service negotiating opening copyright between DEFRA and University of Michigan)

National Food Survey

- Set up in 1940 to monitor the adequacy of the diet of urban working class households in wartime.
- Wealth of information on changing patterns of household food consumption – 7,000-8,000 households per year
- From 2001, amalgamated and now part of Living Costs and Food Survey
- Safeguarded versions: household, visitors, individual and food diary data: a valuable, rich data resource for users and for the UK Data Service
- We can measure service impact with safeguarded data, but what changes will open NFS data bring?

Disclosure, renegotiation, data quality

Common objectives:

- Make open data a worthwhile resource while protecting respondent confidentiality:
  - *Privacy Impact Assessment (PIA)*
- Retain safeguarded access for more detailed data and archive open version:
  - *Licence negotiation*
- Improve user experience of existing safeguarded version:
  - *Aggregate monthly data into user-friendly annual files*
  - *Upgrade formats and provide extra alternatives*
  - *Improve metadata and documentation*

What can data services bring to the table?

- Expertise:
  - *Licencing and copyright*
  - *Anonymisation and disclosure control*
  - *Data and metadata management*
  - *Knowledge of and access to user community*
- Communication and collaboration – keep talking and be open to new possibilities
- Negotiate dates and timelines (rejuvenation of older data can be very resource-intensive; 26 years of data in NFS series)
- Future archiving opportunities: more data (Tiers 2 and 3)

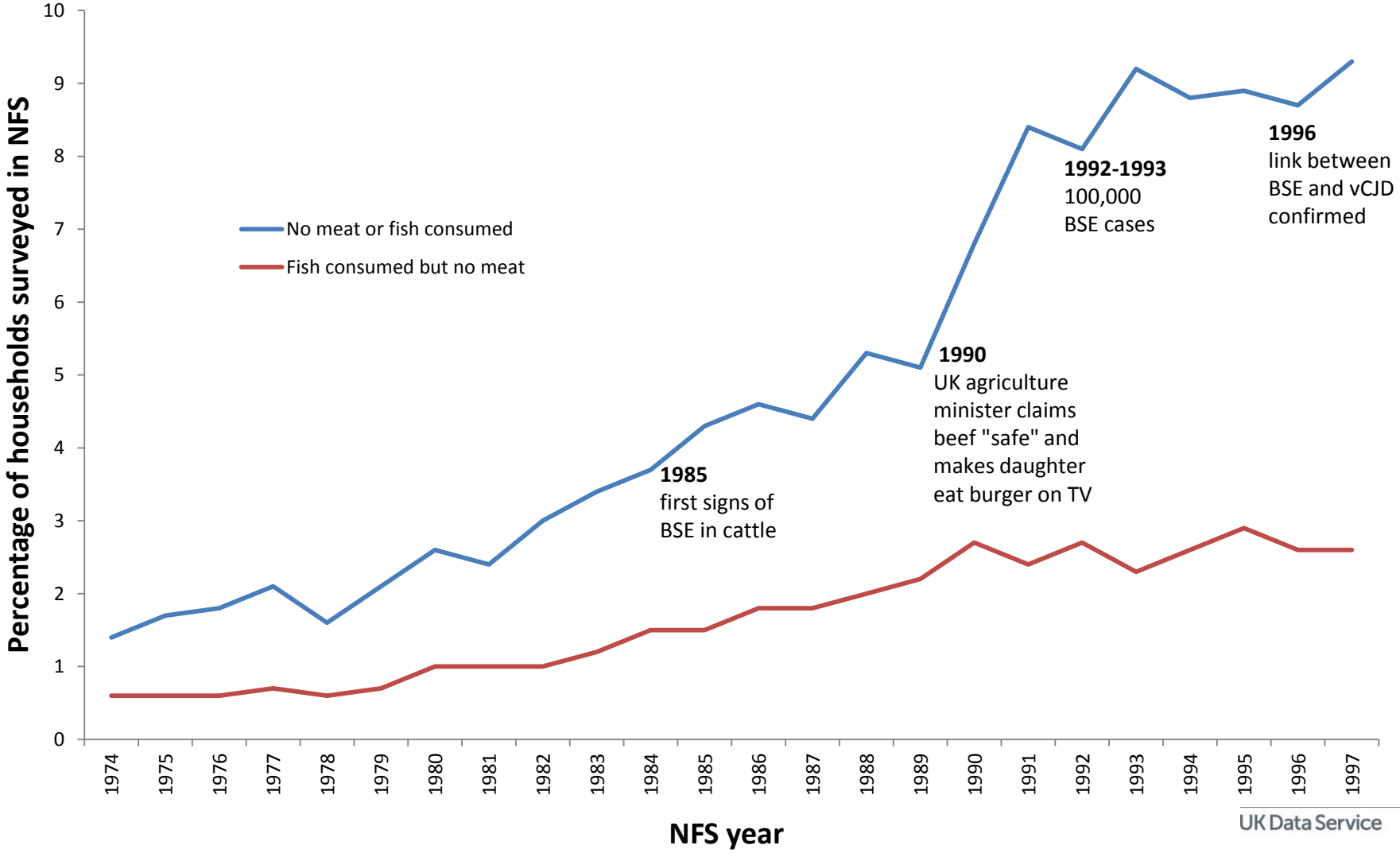
Open food data and citizen empowerment

- What's in the NFS open data?
  - *Household data only; age and gross income banded; households with >10 members removed; weighting incorporated based on household composition by age.*

- What can you do with it? Mash it up!
  - *Graph trends in vegetarianism, using vegetarian indicator variable from 1974-1997*
  - *Augment with relevant food news of the time - BSE and vCJD, taken from The Guardian online BSE crisis timeline*
  - *Simple tools – Excel and the web*

Vegetarianism in Great Britain between 1974 and 1997

using NFS open data and The Guardian's BSE Crisis Timeline



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Links

- NFS data at UK Data Service:
  discover.ukdataservice.ac.uk

- DEFRA Family Food open data page:
  data.gov.uk/dataset/family_food_open_data

- DEFRA Data Blog:
  defradigital.blog.gov.uk/2016/02/18/feeding-the-hunger-for-data/

- NFS 1940-1970s reports:
  https://catalog.hathitrust.org/Record/009079583

- The Guardian's BSE Crisis Timeline:
  www.theguardian.com/uk/2000/oct/26/bse3

- UK government open data
  data.gov.uk

Questions?

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